

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

He should ideally be lying back on a lazy boy, basking in the glory of having sold five crore vada pavs. But the 34-year-old, who along with his wife nurtured Jumbo King, the bright yellow legend with 42 outlets that every on-the-go Mumbaikar is familiar with, is moving at top speed to reach his target of 100 by August this year and

feeding international technology to growing desi appetites.

By Dheeraj Gupta's own admission, making a vada pav—a spicy potato patty dipped in a batter of besan and deep fried, to be served between a specially made bread with different chutneys—isn't rocket science but what this finance graduate from Pune's Symbiosis Institute did was change the way people bite into their high-calorie, low maintenance snack. Drawing inspiration from Ray Kroc, the man who made McDonald's the brand it is today, the Guptas have introduced hygiene, hospitality and standardisation into a snack that has always been a cleanliness freak's trip to the dark side.

The result is that after six years of starting their first outlet, all Jumbo King stores have uniformed staff, top-of-the-line fryers, transfer bins and a vada pav which according to Dheeraj's appeals and appeases people's gluttony at Rs 7. Instead of serving a regular-sized square shaped pav, the store serves a mega-sized round bread with an equally big vada.

“My father said this concept wouldn't work with food so local. But within three months of getting transfer bins, our sales doubled.”

DHEERAJ GUPTA, Founder, Jumbo King



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